

Experience Alchemy

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Golden Idea

Here's the importance of having a base level of experience and how to build it from scratch — by leverage unpaid internships.

Alchemy is an ancient practice that combines elements of science, philosophy, and mysticism, primarily aimed at transforming base metals into gold, discovering a universal elixir, and achieving spiritual enlightenment.

This video is going to teach you how to build experience from nothing — and fill out your resume.

Importance

What's the main reason this idea is important to understand?

- It's very difficult to get any paid internships or jobs in this market when you have zero technical experience — which is why I **always** have new students of the program with little experience get an unpaid, part-time technical role as one of their first steps.
- When the document says "Assignment" pause, and fill out [this](#) worksheet
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Understandings

What are the key points of this video, the main things you should understand about it?

- **My Early Experience**

- This is my resume going into my 2nd year of University. Obviously, there are tons of things I would change about it now, but as you can see, I had tons of work experience even then.
 - I stood on the shoulders of unpaid internships for years. They help you get that first position.
 - So much of this is free work — because I did all of that, I was able to easily leverage into a paid internship my freshman year, then sophomore year, and beyond.



This is also what I looked like — just thought that was funny

My old resume is linked in the Resources section.



Who Needs Unpaid Roles

If you have under 3 technical roles on your resume OR you don't have any role you can call a "Software Engineering Internship", you need to quickly get unpaid positions / internships to boost it.

- ☐ "I have three technical roles that are currently in the work experience section of my resume."
- ☐ "One of them can be titled 'Software Engineering Intern'"

If you already have a few roles / at least one software engineering paid internship, I'd probably not focus on this step — I'd still watch the video, but it's a little less relevant to you.

Specifically, you don't need to do the assignment if you can check off the above boxes — just watch the video and get the context. But if you don't fit the above formula, you are required to complete and submit the accompanying assignment.



What Unpaid Roles Should You Find?

You're going to need to put effort towards all of these categories, and then hopefully a few work out + then you can pick which ones benefit you most. Don't just pick one area hoping that it's going to lead to something.

These examples are formulated for students, but it applies to pretty much everyone looking for unpaid work.

1. Startups

This is you doing unpaid, part-time work at a small company or startup. Startups are more likely to allow you to take this on as they have less red tape. Big companies then have lots of bureaucracy and thus it's a lot harder to get in contact with someone there who can unofficially allow you to work for them.

This is usually the best option for a few reasons:

1. You can clearly write 'Software Engineering Internship' on your resume, which gives you a clear boost.
2. You'll gain relevant experience and also learn a lot about development — you'll pick up new languages, frameworks, and skills you can add to the resume.
3. If you do a great job, you could potentially get a paid role there, but I wouldn't bank on this. This is a very small added bonus.

AM

Now, one of the best ways to get this done is to look at the Entrepreneurship Club / Startup Accelerator of your University.

Assignment: Find three Universities (your University) and two other Universities and link their entrepreneurship or startup club here.

For each one, you're going to fill this out for 5 startups each. List the company name, and the email contact.

- Find ones that are software related.
- Follow up 10 times.

Then, go down the list and check this box off when you've sent them a cold email asking to work for them.

Example: <https://innovationlabs.harvard.edu/venture/skills-tech>

Email template:

How to write a pitch for a consulting gig or a job interview

When you are offering your services to someone who didn't know she needed them, you want to keep your email short and sweet. Provide a highlight or two about what you can do for the person and then make it easy for her to take the next step with a specific call to action.

2-3 BIG PROBLEMS. →

MOST RELEVANT ACHIEVEMENT. →

YOUR OFFER AND A CALL TO ACTION. →

Subject: Hi from John - interested in chatting about Acme

Hi Kelly,

My name is John and I'm currently a Marketing Associate at Widget Corp.
I've been following Acme for some time now -- I love AcmeProduct!

INTRO + COMPLIMENT.

My guess is that right now, 3 of Acme's biggest concerns are

1. Converting free members,
2. Increasing email sign-ups and
3. Hiring good people who know both the marketing and product side.

Recently, I blah blah blah.

I'd love to chat with you about the possibility of doing the same at Acme as a Marketing Manager.

Do you have 15 minutes to meet over coffee Thursday at 10am?

Sincerely,

John Smith

Mention you can easily dedicate 5-10h/week for the next 3 months minimum, and could

do more if needed. Also mention nicely that you completely expect it to be unpaid.

2. Research

Research is a great option here — it's not as good as doing software engineering work for a startup or company, but it's still another great resume boost.

Assignment: List out every computer science/data science/computer engineering professor you've ever had here. Use more lines if necessary.

Then, look them up and see if they actively do research.

If so, **bold their name**. Then, pick three of them that you either know better than the others or you connect with their research more.

For those three, list off three graduate students who work with them each.

You're now going to go through and send them all cold emails using the same framework and check them off once you've sent the cold email.

Modifications:

1. Mention you took a class with them!
2. You're asking for a part-time research job.
3. For the graduate students, mention that you emailed the professor but you wanted to just send them an email as well to make sure your request was seen.

Follow up ~10 times.

3. Clubs

Clubs are another great place to get early experience to boost your resume. They're good, less useful than research and unpaid internships, but still relevant if you fit the criteria of needing more experience — so it's worth your time to utilize them.

Assignment: Fill out this list of 5 clubs or organizations at your University or a neighboring University.

- Software Development Club
- App Development Club
- Hyperloop
- Software Engineering Club
- Blockchain Club



Check them off when you apply to join or contact them directly. Send each and every one an email after you submit your application.

4. Hackathons

Hackathons are great for a multitude of reasons, and I'd recommend that everyone enroll in 1-2 per year — even if you already have a good amount of experience.

You learn a lot, develop new skills, meet new people, build connections through the career fair, and have a good time.

Go to MLH and find all the hackathons coming up in the next year at all the Universities and apply to every single one.

You decide to go once you've already gotten in.

<https://mlh.io/seasons/2025/events>

Might be less relevant if you're not a student — but try and see if you can find company or adult hackathons using Google.

Assignment: Check this box once you've applied to 5 University hackathons or 3 adult hackathons if you're not a student.

List the hackathons and check them off here.

FRIENDS:

- Make a list of every club, research, hackathon, or unpaid internship a friend is doing AND contact them.



The Fortune is in the Follow-Up

Review Psychic Job Hunting. You'll have to follow those tenets, so follow up ~10 times and practice exponential backoff.



Scramble & Reattempt

It's about the numbers — if you don't get anything after a month, then keep on trying but with all different options.



Find new professors, new hackathons, new startups, etc, when the trail goes cold. You stop getting replies or responses from the inputs you fed in.